

MGTA 459: MANAGERIAL DECISION MAKING

Fall 2025

8:00am – 12pm, Sep 27, Oct 11, Oct 25, Nov 8, Nov 22, Dec 6

Otterson 1E107

PROFESSOR: Amos Schurr, aschurr@ucsd.edu

OFFICE HOURS: After each class in 3W101, or by appointment

**Note: This version of the syllabus is provided for your convenience at the start of the course but subject to change. Please log in to Canvas for the most current materials.*

DESCRIPTION

This course is composed of two parts. They are quite distinct yet critically connected: the first is about deriving better analyses and solutions, and the second is about implementing them.

In our initial sessions, we will examine how people make judgments and decisions, concentrating on how people perceive and react to uncertainty and variability. We will lay out key implications for business strategies. Consider a biotech start-up that is attempting to develop a new cancer drug. Suppose its managers must choose between divergent research tracks and market niches, each of which shows some promise but also carries some risks. How will they weigh the promise versus the risks, evaluate relevant information, and settle on a way to proceed? The hope is that a savvy understanding of the answers to such questions can inform your approach to many business settings.

Of course, it is not enough to be skillful at analysis. To succeed in business, you must also be adept at engaging others and getting their buy-in and follow through. For instance, the managers of the biotech start-up may wish to motivate employees and other stakeholders to devote their energies to a particular research approach. They may wish to rally investors around funding this approach. Accordingly, we will also discuss how to best build, protect, and exert influence to achieve your goals. A key idea is that developing multiple tools of influence is beneficial because different circumstances require different approaches.

OBJECTIVES

At the close of this course, you should better understand

- How people think about uncertainty and variability
- How to design effective decision processes
- What influence tactics you tend to rely on
- How to construct a plan for expanding the set of influence tactics you use

MATERIALS

All materials are available on Canvas. In addition, this syllabus contains links to most materials.

SCHEDULE SUMMARY (all times Pacific; deliverables in yellow)

	Topic	BEFORE Class	AFTER Class
PART 1 – HOW PEOPLE MAKE JUDGMENTS AND DECISIONS			
Class 1 Sat. Sep 27	Individual Decision Making	Prior-to-the-Course SURVEY due by 10pm Thu Sept 26	Delusions of Success / Don't Blink Big Idea / Judgment under Uncertainty
Class 2 Sat. Oct 11	Group DM DM Via Models & Algorithms	Managing Group Decisions / Balance Out Biases / What Google Learned Hiring is Hard Podcast / How Google Hires Podcast / Cowen Case (available via Study.Net materials) / Cowen Survey due 11:59pm Th Oct 12 / New Boy Network	Noise HBR Article / Excerpt from Noise Book / Don't Trust Your Gut / BIN There
Class 3 Sat. Oct 25	Risk Taking		Choices, Values, & Frames / Reversals / Midterm due 5pm Thu Nov 7
PART 2 – INFLUENCE			
Class 4 Sat Nov 8	Intro to Influence Coalitions	Introduction & Ch. 1 from Power / The Saudi Arabia of Sashimi	Leverage Inventory Survey: Personalized link emailed to you on 9/27; responses due 11/6
	Networks	Peterson Case (available via Study.Net materials) / Peterson Survey – due 11:59pm Fri Nov 15	What Happens When / Social Capital / Six Degrees
Class 5 Sat Nov 22	Persuasion	de Mello Case: Excerpts from Chasing the Flame / de Mello Survey – due 8am Fri Nov 22 / Harnessing Science of Persuasion / Made to Stick / Persuasive Email Assignment - due 8am Fri Nov 22	
Class 6 Sat Dec 6	Your Influence Toolbox	Abe Lincoln & Influence / Boss of the Little Congress / Review Your Leverage Inventory Results /	Nudge a Lot

		Influence Illustration Assignment - due 11:59pm Wed Nov 29	
Class 6 Sat Dec 7	Influence and Change in Organizations	Google's Project Oxygen case (available via Study.Net materials) / Google Came up with a Formula / Prasad Setty video (watch from 1:33 to 9:32)	Final Project: Personal Action Plan, due 11:59pm Sat Dec 16

HOW THIS COURSE WORKS

During class, we will typically pair an exercise or case discussion with a lecture. Exercises and cases illustrate and explore key concepts; lectures further develop and summarize these concepts.

DELIVERABLES

There are four kinds of deliverables in this course: surveys, assignments, a midterm exam, and a final project. [In the schedule summary on the previous page, individual deliverables are highlighted in yellow.](#) For further information on each of them, follow the included link or see the session-by-session outline later in this syllabus.

GRADING

Your grade will be based on participation (25%), a midterm (35%) and a final project (40%). All assignments are individual.

PARTICIPATION (25%)

Classroom discussion is an integral part of this course. Much of your learning will come from the insights we are able to achieve by collectively mulling course concepts. Moreover, to fully engage with the course material you need to be actively involved in the discussion.

Because it is vital to your learning and the learning of your colleagues, your participation is assessed and factored into your grade. I make notes after each class regarding each student's role in the discussion. So does the teaching assistant. Near the end of the term, I will solicit your input about which students best-facilitated your learning.

We are all jointly responsible for the quality of the discussion. I would like for you to focus on being prepared, engaged and respectful of others. We want to cultivate a direct but friendly environment that encourages honesty and risk-taking. Mistakes are okay, especially as long as we are striving for insight. Irreverence is okay. Questions others know the answer to are okay. As long as you are prepared, engaged and respectful, almost anything goes.

Everyone should participate. This means some of you will have to fight your natural tendencies – those accustomed to speaking might need to back off, those accustomed to not speaking will need to step up. This gives everyone a chance to learn from others' experiences, as well as a chance to work on effective communication.

Finally, your on-time and proper completion of the surveys and other assignments for each class will facilitate our discussions and thus contribute substantially to what you and your colleagues learn. It thus also factors into your grade.

MIDTERM EXAM (35%)

We will have a take-home midterm after the first part of the course. It will be open-book, open-note, individual work. It will consist of a combination of multiple choice and short answer questions. Some of the material on the exam will appear both in class and in the readings, but some of the material will appear either only in class or only in the readings.

FINAL PROJECT – PERSONAL ACTION PLAN (40%)

Your final project is to put together a personal distillation of concepts from the second part of our course. This can take any form – paper, powerpoint, website, video, art project, song, game, etc. Literally any form that works for you. You can think of it as one of those “cheat sheets” that some stats/econ pros allow for their exams. The idea is to boil down as much as possible of what you consider to be the most useful information from the course into a format you can carry forward. The goal is for you to use these ideas in the future. This is intended as a vehicle for that.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

USE OF AI TOOLS

The use of AI tools such as ChatGPT is allowed in this course, with the following condition: Consistent with our emphasis on academic integrity, if you use an AI tool in completing an assignment or exam, please make sure to be transparent about how you have done so. You should include a footnote or citation that summarizes what you have done (e.g., a link to the ChatGPT chat you created).

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.